

Joe Brennan's Luck

By Ruth Lamb

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JOE BRENNAN'S LUCK.

BY

RUTH LAMB

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CHAPTER I.



EVERYBODY thought Joe Brennan was in luck on the bright summer morning, when Kitty Anderton and he became husband and wife, for Kitty was quite the prettiest girl for miles round, and had the prospect of having "a nice penny" of her own some day. Some day meant whenever her mother died; but Mrs. Anderton was a hale woman of forty-five, and Kitty might be an elderly one before she inherited her little fortune.

It was not the prospect of money in the future that made Joe Brennan seek Kitty for a wife. He cared for her, and for her only, and if other people thought him a lucky man on his wedding day, Joe, looking into the fair face of his bride, was equally sure that he was quite the luckiest man that the summer sun shone upon.

Like all true-hearted fellows, Joe was humble in his great happiness. He wondered how such a dainty creature could care for a clumsy fellow like him. His heart swelled within him as he thanked God for the gift of Kitty, and he vowed to love, cherish, and guard her to the very utmost of his power.

So far as outsides went, there was no doubt that Joe had won a prize. But he knew little about his wife's fitness for making home happy, turning his wages to the best account, or managing the small household so as to unite comfort and economy.

In Mrs. Anderton's home, everything was always in apple-pie order. Kitty had been used to the most beautiful cleanliness all her life. She was neat in her person, and her lovely hair was the admiration of everybody. As to her hands! Joe had often laid one of them in his brown palm, and laughed

at the difference in size and colour. He wondered how any person who took a share in housework could have hands so smooth and white as Kitty's.

Joe was afraid Kitty would think his income small, but when he told her all about it, and said how much he wanted to spend, and of his wish to save a little, she declared it "was oceans," and would do everything, and to spare—Joe needn't be uneasy about her managing all right. Beside, if she did want teaching, wasn't there her mother? She could tell her what to do under all circumstances.

Joe was only too glad to be convinced, and as he went off for a fortnight's holiday before settling down in his new home, he could think of nothing but his amazing luck in having won Kitty. A capable young sister of his was to be in the house during their absence, and to have all ready for them on their return.

The days went all too quickly. At the fortnight's end, the pair came home with sun-burned faces, and, Kitty especially, full of delight at the thought of beginning house-keeping on their own account.

Grace Brennan was proud to show her new sister-in-law how nicely everything was ordered for her comfort, and Kitty kissed and thanked her in the prettiest way possible. She looked almost like a child put in possession of a doll's house, as she examined one thing after another, and peeped into every nook, corner, drawer, and cupboard, scarcely having patience to sit still through the meal that was ready when they arrived.

"You have been good, Gracie," said Kitty. "The house is beautiful, and you shall see how nice I will keep it now it is in my hands to look after."

Grace was pleased at having given pleasure, and being a good-natured girl, she was willing to do still more. "If you like, I will stay a night or two longer, and help you until you get used to things," she said.

But Kitty would not hear of this. She was anxious to try her 'prentice hand as mistress of a house, and felt far too full of importance to own that she could want help.

"I mustn't keep you longer now, Gracie. It is very good of you, but I'll not be selfish. Better for me to begin as I shall have to go on; and you know I've had a good fortnight's holiday with Joe. You would spoil me with kindness. I can see that plainly enough."

There was a determined ring in Kitty's voice that told Grace she was in earnest. So after saying that she would always be willing to help, and they must send for her at any time, she left the young couple to themselves.

"Now, Joe, we are housekeepers in earnest," said Kitty. "Grace is as good as gold, but still I did not want anybody here but our two selves. I've heard mother say it was best for young beginners to have their homes to themselves, and specially not to begin with relations under the roof. I'm very fond of mother, but I wouldn't ask her to come, and she knows it. More than that, she wouldn't wish to meddle."

Joe was abundantly content. He saw how useful Grace's help and presence had been whilst they were away; but of course he would rather have only Kitty, and he was delighted that she wanted no one else. He had been a little afraid that she might shrink from undertaking the household work all at once, and it was a pleasant surprise to find how willing she was to do it.

Mrs. Anderton was not near to offer a welcome to Joe and Kitty. She had taken her daughter's marriage very much to heart, though, knowing Joe's character, she had given her consent to it. Still, for a widowed mother to be deprived of the presence of her only daughter was no light trial. And Kitty's was such a bright presence. She looked such a pretty picture as she went in and out, singing in the glad way that a bird sings as it hops from bough to bough. It seemed as if sunshine came and went with Kitty, and Mrs. Anderton was terribly lonely after the wedding was over.

As Grace Brennan was preparing the house for the young couple, there was no work for her there. So when a letter came from an old friend who was going for a month to the seaside, and who wanted a companion, Mrs. Anderton arranged to go with her, and was absent when Kitty returned from her wedding trip.

That first evening did not pass without some forebodings on Joe's part. He had taken his bride's housewifely capacity for granted, and her confident words and manner had led him to think that, as he put it, she "knew all about things." But he quickly found out the secret of Kitty's white hands.

Mrs. Anderton was herself a first-rate house-wife and manager. Strong and capable, it was easier for her to do than to train her daughter in similar accomplishments. What the mother did not choose to do herself, such as the washing and less cleanly housework, she was able to pay for, and a stout charwoman did it under her superintendence, and had to do it well.

Mrs. Anderton was proud of Kitty's beauty, and, having a sufficient income to cover all their modest expenses, she would neither allow the girl to learn any business nor to take any part in housework that would spoil either her clothes or the whiteness of her hands. "She has been used to see me do things, and she's sharp enough. When the time comes, she'll turn to work right enough," said Mrs. Anderton, without any anxieties as to Kitty's fitness for the duties of a wife.

She too thought it was well for young married folk to feel their feet, and was resolved that Joe Brennan should not have cause to complain that his mother-in-law's foot was never off his doorstep.

Kitty was in good hands, for Joe almost worshipped the ground she trod on. And her mother, judging that two such true lovers would find each other's society enough during the early days of married life, left them to themselves with a clear conscience.

If anybody could have read Mrs. Anderton's thoughts, a little under-current of feeling would have been found there—one which she would have hesitated to put into words. It was somewhat of this kind—

"Kitty has been so taken up with Joe since I agreed to the marriage, that I am nobody. It's natural he should be first, but she might think of all I've done for her, and how she has been indulged. She will want my advice and help before long, though she gives herself a few airs now, and is very independent. I'll keep out of reach for a bit, and she'll learn the value of

having her mother to run to. She has plenty to learn beside that, and so she'll find."

CHAPTER II.

SIX weeks—only six weeks since Joe and Kitty Brennan settled down to married life in their own home. What an altered home it was, and what an altered couple were the husband and wife already! From the first day that the work had to be done by Kitty's white hands, it became plain how unused they were to the task before them. It was a new experience for the girl-wife to have to think and plan for a husband as well as herself.

At first she was willing, and faced the getting up early, the fire-making and house-cleaning, the cooking and clearing away, cheerfully enough, though her inexperience and want of method greatly increased her work, and left her needlessly weary when evening came.

Joe, used to excellent management at home, could see the mistakes Kitty made, the extra trouble she caused herself, the needless steps, the waste cause by ignorance and haste. He wanted to help, and was able to do it; but Kitty stood on her new dignity, and would not be interfered with, she said.

So ill-cooked food, an untidy table, a house in which everything was at sixes and sevens, became the rule. There was a place for everything, and everything in its place, when Grace Brennan showed Kitty through the new home. Now, after only a few weeks, everything was out of place.

If Kitty could but have felt her own deficiency, she would have wished to mend it, but she found fault with all but herself. "If this house were like ours, I could manage better. If I could have a woman to come in and help, as mother used to have, I should not find the rest too much. I could do the ironing, but the washing rubs the skin off my hands. They are getting so rough and horrid to look at."

Kitty held up her hands and seemed ready to cry, because they were no longer white and smooth as they used to be.

"You know, Kitty dear, I told you just what I had to keep house on, and that till I got my next rise, we must not have help in the work. You were so sure you could manage."

"I know, Joe. You needn't bring up what I said. I knew no better, and I felt certain mother would do something to help out. And now she is gone away, and does not even say when she is coming back. She said she was so grieved about me leaving her alone, and now she has left me and mightn't have a daughter. I heard that somebody wants her to marry again. It will be a shame if she does marry, but I'm glad she can't prevent me having the money after she has done with it."

"I don't believe a word of that tale," said Joe.

"Do you think I'm telling a story, then?" asked Kitty, angrily. "I tell you I heard it from Mrs. Willis!"

"My dear, I'm sure you would tell nothing but the truth. All the same, I pay little heed to Mrs. Willis and her tales, so be comforted. I'm going down home. Shall I ask Grace to come and help you straighten up?"

Kitty would have been glad of such help, but two reasons made her say, "No, thank you, Joe; I'll manage without Grace."

First, she did not like to own that her sister-in-law knew so much better than herself how to do the work of a house. Second, she felt ashamed that Grace should see how different both she and her home looked after so short a time.

Joe sighed and went his way, painfully conscious that many of his friends were already doubting whether he had really been in luck when he took to wife pretty Kitty Anderton.

Joe said nothing about domestic difficulties to his own people, but when kind enquiries were made, he answered them and said, with perfect truth, that Kitty was too busy to come with him, but sent her love to them all and a special share for Grace.

At home, Kitty was muddling on in much confusion, yet feeling dissatisfied with herself. Joe was so patient and kind, never speaking angrily or fault-finding, but bearing so much and always ready to praise the least thing that could be honestly praised. She thought how different his old orderly home would look. She glanced in the glass, and could hardly believe that the image she saw there was a reflection of her who was so smart and tidy as Kitty Anderton. Whilst doing her best, according to her knowledge, she also resolved that the next morning should see her up early and driving her work, instead of letting it drive her.

When Joe came home, he brought pleasant messages, and was so kind and loving, and seemingly so blind to all defects, that Kitty felt more and more anxious to keep her resolutions and become a real good, clever wife to such a husband. But ignorance, disorder, and want of method are enemies not to be conquered by mere resolutions, though these must be the beginnings that lead to improvement.

Kitty stole downstairs on the following morning much earlier than was needful. If she had remembered to wind up the cuckoo clock, she would have known the right time. She could not reach Joe's watch without waking him, and she meant to surprise him by what she would get done before he came down.

When nearly at the foot of the stairs, she found out that she had forgotten the matchbox she meant to bring. Two of the steps would creak under her light weight, so she determined not to go back, as there was a full matchbox in the kitchen. She began to grope for this, but before she found it, she knocked down a jug and broke it, beside making a great clatter.

It was something to have found the matches, and she opened the box quickly and fully without first feeling whether it was the right side up or not. It was wrong, and away went the matches all over the floor.

Kitty had got hold of that word luck, and was very fond of using it. Whenever anything went wrong, no matter how much she might have been to blame for forgetfulness or carelessness, she was sure to say, "It's just my luck. Such things don't happen to other people. I am an unlucky creature."

She was right. They only happened to people who paved the way for them by their own doing, or leaving undone what would have prevented the mishap.

On this morning, Kitty had said very softly, not to wake Joe, "It's just my luck," when she found the clock stopped, when the stairs creaked, when she forgot the matchbox, when she broke the jug, and when she spilled the matches through holding them the wrong way up. However, amongst so many she soon found one, and obtained a light which enabled her to gather up the rest.

"It's just my luck," said Kitty once more, as she found that she had used more than double the proper allowance of firewood through being late the morning before, and had forgotten to order any more all through its not being the day on which she was used to get in a supply for the week.

She had some wood, but it needed drying, and it was a very long business to get it to burn at all. However, it burned at last, and then, Kitty feeling that it would take a long time to get the kettle boiling, determined to put it on at once.

It would not do to crush the fire altogether, so she placed the kettle very gingerly on the coals, but not touching the bar. It was pleasant to see the blaze rising higher, and Kitty thought for once her luck was on the right side, and rejoiced accordingly.

She turned to begin her work, when lo! the kettle slipped, and went over to one side, through the blaze having consumed the supporting wood. Half the water went on to the still struggling flame and extinguished it completely.

All had to be done over again. Kitty was ready to cry and to give up as she whimpered, "It's just my luck! If I make up my mind that I'll get things put straight, I'm always disappointed. If I'd only thought to prop the kettle on the bar, it would have been firm."

The fire must be relighted, and this time the task would be more difficult, as the contents of the grate were all wet, and the best of the wood

had been used for the first attempt. Time was flying as fast as usual, and Kitty was thinking that Joe would be down before she had begun her efforts at improving the state of the kitchen.

Once more she drew the matchbox open, but only half-way. Unfortunately, in her haste, she struck the match before closing it again. It was of the sort which will only light by rubbing on the box. She ought to have rubbed gently if she had carried out the directions. She struck sharply, and the head of the match flew off and into the box amongst the rest. These all exploded at once, and poor Kitty's hand was sadly burned, though she dropped the box as quickly as she could.

She was holding it over the table on which the supper cloth still lay, and of course the burning matches set it on fire.

Fully alive to the danger, she managed to put it out. But the cloth was ruined, and she was conscious that if it had been shaken and put away the night before, the loss would have been prevented.

Poor Kitty! Her hand was terribly painful, but help was at hand. She had given a sharp cry when the matches exploded. For once her forgetfulness in leaving the staircase door open was lucky, for Joe heard the cry, smelled the burning cloth, and rushed down to find out what was the matter, and to remedy the mischief as far as possible.

Fortunately, he knew what to do and had materials at hand, and very soon the burn was attended to, and giving her much less pain.

There was nothing for it but to fetch Grace to the rescue, and very thankful was Kitty when she saw her sister-in-law's kind face. Through the day she watched Grace's thorough work and the orderly manner in which it was done. She realised her kindness in coming, and the further kindness of her silence with regard to all that she found so different from what she left it.

Kitty was enabled to see herself also, and to contrast her doings with those of Grace, her wifely deficiencies with her husband's tender patience. She sobbed out her confession on his breast as his strong arm held her there.

She owned her pride, her self-satisfaction, her ignorance, even her jealousy of Grace's superior domestic abilities, and begged that she might be allowed to learn from her sister-in-law how to make Joe's house a real home. More than all, she asked God to strengthen, guide, and help her for the future, and to forgive, for Christ's sake, all that had been wrong in the past.

That chapter of accidents proved a bit of real good luck after all, and brighter days began from that time. Grace proved the gentlest, most patient of teachers; Kitty as ready and humble a learner. Each day made them truer friends, until at last Kitty said that one of the best presents Joe ever gave her was dear kind Gracie for a sister. There was no talk of sisters-in-law after that time, and in place of feeling jealous of Grace's superior knowledge, Kitty was humbly anxious to become more like her.

In due time Mrs. Anderton returned, and met with the most loving of welcomes from her daughter. She was looking much better for her long holiday, and seemed to have brought back for her child an extra share of affection. Her face fairly beamed with gladness as she clasped the girl-wife to her motherly breast and kissed her with more than the old tenderness.

"Mother, I have so wanted you," said Kitty. "Joe is the best husband in the world, but nobody can ever take mother's place. There's one sort of love for him, and plenty of it, and another sort for you, and plenty of it too; there can be no clashing between them. I hope I shall be a better daughter for having found out what an ignorant creature I am as a wife. I thought I knew everything, and now I know that I have nearly everything to learn. But I'm willing to be taught now, and that is a step in the right direction, isn't it?"

As to Mrs. Anderton, it seemed as though her affection for her child had so accumulated in her absence that Kitty felt doubly enriched in being the object of so much tenderness. There was nothing in her mother's manner that suggested the probability of a second marriage, and Kitty shrank from asking her if there was any truth in the report which had reached her.

However, the gossip who had made her uneasy by her tattle had told the tale to others, and Mrs. Anderton soon received congratulations from her friends and neighbours. She promptly assured them that their congratulations were misplaced, and hastened to speak to Kitty on the

subject, lest she too should have been misled and rendered anxious by the idle gossip of Mrs. Willis.

"Joe said he was certain there was no truth in it or you would have told me, mother dear. I am so glad, for I want to keep you to myself," said Kitty.

"Then you did believe it, Kitty, and Joe did not? Thank you, Joe," said Mrs. Anderton. "You had more faith in me than my own girl had."

The speaker did not think less of her son-in-law for, as she said, giving her credit for common sense.

"I did not quite believe it, mother, but when people are so positive, you hardly know what to think."

"Well, child, you have got a lesson in this as well as in other things, and I hope you won't make yourself miserable again by listening to gossip about your mother—or indeed about anybody for that matter," said Mrs. Anderton.

And Kitty acted on her advice.

The young wife is nursing her first baby now, and makes an excellent mother. Her hands are not so white as they were in her maiden days, but they are useful, capable hands, and therefore worthy of all admiration. Joe feels certain that Kitty is prettier than ever. She makes his life very happy, and he reaps the fruit of his patience with her early deficiencies in her tender anxiety for his comfort in their well-ordered home. No one who sees the pair together nowadays can have the smallest doubt about the reality of Joe Brennan's luck.



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